

Alternative English · Half-yearly 2026

Harmony | ASSEB HS 2nd Year | Revision companion

This guide follows the syllabus supplied by the student: six literature selections, common errors, question tags, voice, tense and comprehension. The chapter notes use the downloaded *Harmony* textbook. Questions and exercises are for practice, not predictions. The marks and choices on the actual half-yearly paper may differ.

How to use this guide

Read each chapter's short summary and details, then cover the answers and test yourself. For a one-mark answer, give one clear fact; for a longer answer, start directly, add details from the text, and explain the theme if asked. For comprehension, read the passage before answering; do not add facts that are not in it. In grammar, rewrite the complete sentence and check the verb, subject and time clue.

Exact half-yearly scope

- **Literature:** A Cup of Tea; The Voyage; The Verger; Ozymandias of Egypt; Because I Could Not Stop for Death; Strange Meeting.
- **Grammar:** Common errors; question tag; voice; tense.
- **Reading:** Comprehension.

The textbook prints “Because I Could Not Stop for Death”; the supplied syllabus says “Because I Couldn't Stop for Death.” Both refer to the same poem. Essay writing is not listed in this half-yearly syllabus; ten optional model essays are included separately for extra writing practice.

Part I · Literature

1. A Cup of Tea — Katherine Mansfield

Summary. Wealthy Rosemary Fell meets a hungry young woman, Miss Smith, outside an antique shop. Instead of giving her tea money, Rosemary takes her home, delighted by the idea of playing the generous heroine. She feeds her guest, but her husband Philip calls Miss Smith “astonishingly pretty.” Rosemary’s jealousy displaces her charity: she gives the girl money and sends her away. Her final question to Philip — “am I pretty?” — reveals her insecurity and the limits of her kindness.

Notable details. Rosemary admires an enamel box priced at **twenty-eight guineas** but initially leaves it in the shop. Miss Smith asks only for the price of a cup of tea. Rosemary takes **three five-pound notes** after putting two of five notes back; the story does not directly show the handover, though

Rosemary says she gave Miss Smith money. Its contrasts are luxury versus hunger, and professed charity versus vanity.

Short Q&A 1. **Who is Rosemary Fell?** A rich, fashionable young woman married to Philip. 2. **What does Miss Smith ask for?** The price of a cup of tea. 3. **Why does Rosemary send her away?** Philip's praise of Miss Smith's beauty makes Rosemary jealous. 4. **What does Rosemary ask Philip at the end?** "Am I pretty?"

MCQs 1. Who wrote the story? A) Emily Dickinson B) Katherine Mansfield C) W. Somerset Maugham D) P. B. Shelley. **Answer: B.** 2. What does Rosemary examine in the antique shop? A) A ring B) A vase C) An enamel box D) A portrait. **Answer: C.** 3. What is the young woman's name? A) Miss Smith B) Miss Brown C) Miss Rose D) Miss Jones. **Answer: A.** 4. Which remark unsettles Rosemary? A) The girl is wealthy B) The girl is astonishingly pretty C) The box is sold D) Philip is leaving. **Answer: B.**

2. The Voyage — Bhupen Hazarika

Summary. Hazarika recalls his journey abroad towards the United States in **1949**, travelling through India and Sri Lanka, then taking a sea voyage from Colombo towards Marseille. A forgotten bag containing travel papers briefly delays his departure at Guwahati's Kanhikuchi Airport. In Sri Lanka he observes cultural links between its dance and Assam's traditions. On the voyage he notices poverty at Djibouti and memorable sights at sea, including a star near the crescent moon and luminous fish. His outward journey also enlarges his sense of cultural kinship and Indian identity.

Notable details. He planned an indirect route to see more places; the ship journey from Colombo to Marseille was to take **thirteen days**. The Sri Lankan **Yakuma Natum** recalls Assam's **deodhani** dance. He buys a **Rolleiflex camera at Aden**; at Djibouti he observes poverty; he does **not** see the pyramids on this journey. Do not confuse this autobiographical travel account with a generic allegory of a river or attribute it to Katherine Mansfield.

Short Q&A 1. **Why was the plane stopped at Kanhikuchi?** Hazarika discovered that his bag with his passport and other papers was missing; it was fetched before the flight continued. 2. **Why did he choose an indirect route?** He wished to see other countries and cultures on his way abroad. 3. **What Assamese dance did the Yakuma Natum recall?** Deodhani dance. 4. **What two unusual sights did he see at sea?** A star beside or above the crescent moon, and luminous phosphorescent fish.

MCQs 1. Who narrates *The Voyage*? A) Albert Edward Foreman B) Bhupen Hazarika C) Philip Fell D) Percy Shelley. **Answer: B.** 2. In what year did the journey begin? A) 1919 B) 1939 C) 1949 D) 1969. **Answer: C.** 3. Where did he board the ship for Marseille? A) Guwahati B) Colombo C) Paris D) Djibouti. **Answer: B.** 4. What did he buy at Aden? A) A Rolleiflex camera B) A pair of shoes C) A radio D) A painting. **Answer: A.**

3. The Verger — W. Somerset Maugham

Summary. Albert Edward Foreman has served for sixteen years as verger of St Peter's, Neville Square. The new vicar learns that he cannot read or write and demands that he learn within three months or leave. Foreman resigns. While walking home, he finds a street without a tobacco shop and opens one himself.

His tobacconist-and-newsagent business expands to ten shops and substantial savings. When a bank manager wonders what he could have become if literate, Foreman replies that he would have remained the verger. The irony celebrates practical judgement while exposing the vicar's narrow measure of ability.

Notable details. The new vicar praises Foreman's work but regards illiteracy as an unacceptable risk. Foreman notices the opportunity when he wants a cigarette and cannot find a shop. He learns to **sign his name after entering business**; he does **not** become fully literate. After ten years his deposit is **a little over £30,000**. The ending is ironic, not an argument that schooling is worthless.

Short Q&A 1. **Where and how long had Foreman been verger?** At St Peter's, Neville Square, for sixteen years. 2. **What condition did the new vicar impose?** Learn to read and write within three months or leave the post. 3. **How did Foreman find his business idea?** He found no shop selling cigarettes on a long street and spotted an unmet demand. 4. **What is his answer to the bank manager's final question?** If he could read and write, he would still be verger of St Peter's.

MCQs 1. What is Foreman's first name? A) Philip B) Albert Edward C) Andre D) William. **Answer: B.** 2. What made the new vicar demand a change? A) Theft B) Foreman's illiteracy C) Late attendance D) Smoking in church. **Answer: B.** 3. What business does Foreman establish? A) Florist B) Bookbinder C) Tobacconist and newsagent D) Bank. **Answer: C.** 4. How many shops does he acquire within ten years? A) Two B) Five C) Ten D) Twenty. **Answer: C.**

4. Ozymandias of Egypt — Percy Bysshe Shelley

Summary. A traveller describes the broken statue of Ozymandias in a vast desert: two trunkless legs stand near a shattered face. The sculptor has preserved the ruler's arrogant expression, and the pedestal boasts of the king's mighty works. Yet no empire remains in sight—only the ruined monument and endless sand. The boast becomes ironic: political power decays, while art and the poem preserve its memory.

Notable details. The poem is a **sonnet** framed as the traveller's report; the speaker did not claim to see the ruins firsthand. The sculptor captured the "sneer of cold command." "Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!" is written on the pedestal, but "Nothing beside remains." The textbook title adds "**of Egypt**" to the familiar poem title *Ozymandias*.

Short Q&A 1. **Who describes the statue to the speaker?** A traveller from an antique land. 2. **What remains of the statue?** Two huge trunkless legs, a half-buried broken face, and its pedestal. 3. **What does the sculptor capture?** The king's proud, harsh expression and passions. 4. **Why is the inscription ironic?** It praises magnificent works where only a wreck and empty desert remain.

MCQs 1. Who wrote the poem? A) Shelley B) Dickinson C) Mansfield D) Maugham. **Answer: A.** 2. What is the statue's face called? A) Tippet B) Visage C) Cornice D) Gown. **Answer: B.** 3. What surrounds the wreck? A) Palaces B) Forest C) Lone, level sands D) Crowds. **Answer: C.** 4. What does "king of kings" express in context? A) Humility B) Ozymandias's pride C) The sculptor's name D) The traveller's fear. **Answer: B.**

5. Because I Could Not Stop for Death — Emily Dickinson

Summary. The speaker imagines Death as a courteous carriage companion who stops for her; Immortality also rides with them. They pass a school, fields of grain, and the setting sun. The mood darkens as the sun passes them and the air turns cold. They pause at a house resembling a swelling in the ground—a grave. Looking back after centuries, the speaker recalls realizing that the horses were travelling towards Eternity. The poem presents death as a journey, but its chill and final uncertainty complicate the initial courtesy.

Notable details. Death is **personified** as “kindly” and marked by “Civility”; the carriage contains the speaker, Death and Immortality. The three passing scenes can suggest stages of life, though that is an interpretation rather than an explicit label in the text. In the original poem the speaker corrects herself: “Or rather—He passed Us—” after saying they passed the setting sun. The barely visible roof and buried cornice identify the “House” as a grave; “Gossamer” and “Tulle” show how lightly she is dressed against the cold.

Short Q&A 1. **Who stops for the speaker?** Death, imagined as a courteous companion. 2. **Who else rides in the carriage?** Immortality. 3. **Which scenes do they pass?** A school with children, fields of gazing grain, and the setting sun. 4. **What is the house in the ground?** The grave.

MCQs 1. Who wrote the poem? A) Mansfield B) Dickinson C) Shelley D) Hazarika. **Answer: B.** 2. How does Death travel? A) By ship B) On foot C) In a carriage D) By train. **Answer: C.** 3. What does the speaker wear against the chill? A) A wool coat B) Gossamer and tulle C) Armour D) A shawl of fur. **Answer: B.** 4. Towards what are the horses’ heads directed? A) School B) The sea C) Eternity D) The palace. **Answer: C.**

6. Strange Meeting — Wilfred Owen

In brief. A soldier seems to escape battle through a deep tunnel. In a gloomy hall, he meets another dead soldier. The stranger tells him about the hopes, beauty and truth that war cut short. He wanted people to understand “the pity of war,” but violence silenced him. At the end, he says he is the enemy the speaker killed the day before. He calls the speaker “my friend” and asks them both to sleep. The poem shows the suffering shared by men who have been made enemies.

Remember. The meeting happens in a place the speaker recognises as Hell. The enemy is not a monster: he had hopes and gifts of his own. “The pity of war” matters more to Owen than tales of glory. The last words, “Let us sleep now,” suggest death, rest and an end to fighting.

Short Q&A

1. **Who wrote “Strange Meeting”?** Wilfred Owen.
2. **Where does the speaker meet the other soldier?** In a dark underground hall that he recognises as Hell.
3. **How does the speaker know that they are in Hell?** He recognises it from the other man's dead smile.
4. **What does the stranger call the speaker?** He calls him his friend, even though the speaker killed him.

5. **What truth did the stranger want to tell?** He wanted to tell people about the pity and suffering caused by war.
6. **Why is the meeting strange?** The speaker meets the enemy he killed, but they speak as fellow human beings rather than enemies.
7. **What do the final words “Let us sleep now” suggest?** They suggest rest in death after the pain of war.
8. **What is the central idea of the poem?** War destroys lives and hopes; soldiers on opposite sides share the same humanity.

MCQs

1. Who wrote “Strange Meeting”? A) Shelley B) Wilfred Owen C) Dickinson D) Maugham. **Answer: B.**
2. Where does the speaker go after escaping battle? A) A garden B) A classroom C) A deep tunnel D) A palace. **Answer: C.**
3. What tells the speaker that they are in Hell? A) The sun B) A dead smile C) A trumpet D) A river. **Answer: B.**
4. What had the dead soldier hoped to reveal? A) The pity of war B) A hidden treasure C) A map D) A new weapon. **Answer: A.**
5. Who is the other soldier? A) His brother B) His teacher C) The enemy he killed D) A general. **Answer: C.**
6. How does the other soldier address him? A) Stranger B) Captain C) Friend D) King. **Answer: C.**
7. What does “Let us sleep now” suggest? A) A holiday B) Rest in death C) A victory D) A journey home. **Answer: B.**
8. What does the poem question? A) The glory of war B) The value of friendship C) The beauty of nature D) The need for books. **Answer: A.**

Deeper answers to practise

A Cup of Tea

Why does Rosemary take Miss Smith home? Rosemary is moved by the girl's hunger, but she also likes the thought of doing something dramatic and generous, like a scene from a novel. Her invitation has kindness in it, yet she imagines telling her friends about it. The story makes us question whether she sees Miss Smith as a person or as a part in her own adventure.

How is the ending ironic? Rosemary has spoken of helping a poor woman and of sisterhood. But when Philip praises Miss Smith's beauty, Rosemary's concern turns to jealousy. She sends the girl away with money and asks Philip whether she herself is pretty. The woman who seemed secure in her wealth ends up seeking reassurance about her looks.

The Voyage

How does travel change Hazarika's sense of home? At first he misses Assam deeply, carrying a drying flower given to him at the airport. Farther from home, he feels attached to all of India. In Sri Lanka, local dance and Buddhist places remind him of Indian and Assamese traditions. He sees that culture can

connect people beyond political borders.

What makes the voyage more than a travel diary? Besides places and incidents, Hazarika records how they affect him. The forgotten bag shows a nervous beginning; Sri Lankan dance shows cultural kinship; poverty in Djibouti troubles him; the moon and luminous fish fill him with wonder. The journey becomes an account of curiosity, human sympathy and a widening sense of belonging.

The Verger

Why did Foreman lose his job despite serving well? The new vicar discovers that Foreman cannot read or write. Although Foreman has served St Peter's faithfully for sixteen years, the vicar considers his illiteracy an unacceptable risk. He gives Foreman three months to learn. Foreman refuses and resigns, choosing dignity rather than accepting the condition.

Explain the last line. The bank manager wonders what Foreman might have become had he been literate. Foreman replies that he would still be verger at St Peter's. If he had kept that job, he would never have noticed the empty market for a tobacco shop. The ending turns a setback into an unexpected opportunity without saying that education itself is useless.

Ozymandias of Egypt

What is the central idea of the poem? Ozymandias calls himself "King of Kings" and orders the powerful to admire his works. Yet his statue lies broken, and empty sand surrounds it. Time has outlasted his empire. The sculptor's skill preserves the king's proud expression, but cannot preserve his rule. The poem questions pride in political power.

Explain the irony of the inscription. The pedestal commands the mighty to look upon Ozymandias's works and despair. The traveller sees no mighty works nearby: only broken stone and "lone and level sands." The words meant to proclaim lasting greatness now reveal how completely that greatness has vanished.

Because I Could Not Stop for Death

What do the scenes on the journey suggest? The school with children, fields of grain and setting sun may suggest childhood, maturity and the close of life. The poem does not label the stages outright; the speaker observes them as the carriage moves slowly on. When the sun passes them and the air grows cold, Death's gentle manner feels less comforting.

Why is the house important? The "House" is a grave, suggested by its swelling ground, scarcely visible roof and cornice in the earth. Death's polite carriage ride pauses there. From that point the speaker speaks as someone who has been dead for centuries, looking back on a journey that leads toward Eternity.

Strange Meeting

What makes this meeting strange? The speaker meets a soldier he killed only yesterday. In life they fought on opposite sides; after death the man calls him "my friend." Their conversation reveals shared hopes and suffering. The enemy is no longer a faceless target but a human being whose future was taken away.

How does Owen show the pity of war? The dead soldier remembers the beauty and truth he wished to seek and share. War ended those possibilities. His words about blood, wounds and lost progress challenge the idea that war brings honour. Even the killer and the killed can understand each other, but only after both are dead.

Part II · Comprehension practice

Start with the reading exercise you supplied (Philosophy of Education, five MCQs); its full passage, options and explained answers appear below. Then try the four original conversation passages for extra practice. Neither is a prediction of the half-yearly format.

Priority practice · Reading Comprehension Exercise (student-supplied PDF)

Start here: this exercise was supplied for this revision. It is practice, not a prediction of the half-yearly passage.

Passage: Philosophy of Education

Philosophy of Education is a label applied to the study of the purpose, process, nature and ideals of education. It can be considered a branch of both philosophy and education. Education can be defined as the teaching and learning of specific skills, and the imparting of knowledge, judgment and wisdom, and is something broader than the societal institution of education we often speak of.

Many educationalists consider it a weak and woolly field, too far removed from the practical applications of the real world to be useful. But philosophers dating back to Plato and the Ancient Greeks have given the area much thought and emphasis, and there is little doubt that their work has helped shape the practice of education over the millennia.

Plato is the earliest important educational thinker, and education is an essential element in "The Republic" (his most important work on philosophy and political theory, written around 360 B.C.). In it, he advocates some rather extreme methods: removing children from their mothers' care and raising them as wards of the state, and differentiating children suitable to the various castes, the highest receiving the most education, so that they could act as guardians of the city and care for the less able. He believed that education should be holistic, including facts, skills, physical discipline, music and art. Plato believed that talent and intelligence is not distributed genetically and thus is to be found in children born to all classes, although his proposed system of selective public education for an educated minority of the population does not really follow a democratic model.

Aristotle considered human nature, habit and reason to be equally important forces to be cultivated in education, the ultimate aim of which should be to produce good and virtuous citizens. He proposed that teachers lead their students systematically, and that repetition be used as a key tool to develop good habits, unlike Socrates' emphasis on questioning his listeners to bring out their own ideas. He emphasized the balancing of the theoretical and practical aspects of subjects taught, among which he explicitly mentions reading, writing, mathematics, music, physical education, literature, history, and a wide range of sciences, as well as play, which he also considered important.

During the Medieval period, the idea of Perennialism was first formulated by St. Thomas Aquinas in his work "De Magistro". Perennialism holds that one should teach those things deemed to be of everlasting importance to all people everywhere, namely principles and reasoning, not just facts (which are apt to change over time), and that one should teach first about people, not machines or techniques. It was originally religious in nature, and it was only much later that a theory of secular perennialism developed.

During the Renaissance, the French skeptic Michel de Montaigne (1533 - 1592) was one of the first to critically look at education. Unusually for his time, Montaigne was willing to question the conventional wisdom of the period, calling into question the whole edifice of the educational system, and the implicit assumption that university-educated philosophers were necessarily wiser than uneducated farm workers, for example.

Multiple-choice questions

Q1. What is the difference between the approaches of Socrates and Aristotle?

- 1) Aristotle felt the need for repetition to develop good habits in students; Socrates felt that students need to be constantly questioned
- 2) Aristotle felt the need for rote-learning; Socrates emphasized on dialogic learning
- 3) There was no difference
- 4) Aristotle emphasized on the importance of paying attention to human nature; Socrates emphasized upon science

Answer: 1. The passage says Aristotle used repetition to develop good habits; Socrates used questions to bring out ideas.

Q2. Why do educationists consider philosophy a 'weak and woolly' field?

- 1) It is not practically applicable
- 2) Its theoretical concepts are easily understood
- 3) It is irrelevant for education
- 4) None of the above

Answer: 1. They consider it too far removed from practical applications in the real world.

Q3. What do you understand by the term 'Perennialism', in the context of the given comprehension passage?

- 1) It refers to something which is of ceaseless importance
- 2) It refers to something which is quite unnecessary
- 3) It refers to something which is abstract and theoretical
- 4) It refers to something which existed in the past and no longer exists now

Answer: 1. Perennialism focuses on principles and reasoning of lasting importance.

Q4. Were Plato's beliefs about education democratic?

- 1) He believed that only the rich have the right to acquire education
- 2) Yes
- 3) He believed that only a select few are meant to attend schools
- 4) He believed that all pupils are not talented

Answer: 3. The passage says his selective education for a minority did not follow a democratic model. Option 3 is the closest choice, though its wording about schools is less precise than the passage.

Q5. Why did Aquinas propose a model of education which did not lay much emphasis on facts?

- 1) Facts are not important
- 2) Facts do not lead to holistic education
- 3) Facts change with the changing times
- 4) Facts are frozen in time

Answer: 3. The passage says facts can change over time, whereas principles and reasoning have lasting value.

Source: Student-supplied *Reading_Comprehension_Exercise.pdf*, pp. 1–3. The passage and options are reproduced from that file; explanations and the closest-choice answer key are revision guidance.

Read each conversation, then answer in full sentences. These passages and answer keys are original practice, not an official exam pattern.

Passage A: A school reading corner

Rina: Why are these books in the corridor, Kabir?

Kabir: Our class is setting up a reading corner. The library closes before some bus students can visit it.

Rina: Where will the books come from?

Kabir: Teachers have donated twenty books, and students may lend one each. We will write the owner's name inside every borrowed book.

Rina: Who will look after them?

Kabir: Two volunteers will take turns at lunch. They will record loans in a notebook and return the books on Fridays.

Rina: Can anyone use the corner?

Kabir: Yes, but the books must remain in good condition. Our aim is access, not a competition over who reads most.

1. Why is the class setting up a reading corner? (2)
2. Give two sources of books. (2)
3. How will the volunteers manage loans? (2)
4. What is Kabir's aim, and what must readers do? (2)
5. Find words in the passage meaning (i) people who offer help without being required to; (ii) reach or opportunity to use something. (1 + 1)

Answers: 1. Some bus students cannot visit the library before it closes, so the class is creating another place to read. 2. Teachers donate books, and students lend books. 3. Two volunteers take turns at lunch, record loans in a notebook and return books on Fridays. 4. He wants access rather than a reading contest; readers must keep the books in good condition. 5. (i) volunteers; (ii) access.

Passage B: Choosing a course

Mother: You seem uncertain about your course application, Neel.

Neel: I enjoy biology, but my friends think I should study engineering.

Mother: Have you asked a teacher about your options?

Neel: Yes. Sen Ma'am suggested that I compare the subjects and talk to people who work in both fields.

Mother: That sounds sensible. Is the deadline close?

Neel: It is next Monday. I will visit the college website tonight and write down my questions.

Mother: What matters most to you?

Neel: I want a course that suits my interests and abilities, not merely one that sounds fashionable.

Mother: Then make a careful choice. We can discuss the costs together tomorrow.

1. Which subject does Neel enjoy? (1)
2. Why does he feel pulled towards engineering? (1)
3. What two steps did Sen Ma'am suggest? (2)
4. What will Neel do tonight and when is the deadline? (2)
5. Explain Neel's view of a suitable course. (3)
6. Find a word meaning "reasonable and practical." (1)

Answers: 1. Biology. 2. His friends think he should study engineering. 3. Compare the subjects and speak to people working in both fields. 4. He will visit the college website and note his questions tonight; the deadline is next Monday. 5. It should match his interests and abilities; he does not want to choose merely because a course is fashionable. 6. sensible.

Passage C: A cleaner festival

Tara: Will the festival committee still give out plastic cups?

Imran: No. We have arranged steel cups that can be washed and reused.

Tara: Who will wash them during the event?

Imran: Volunteers will collect them at two return desks. A local group will wash them in clean water behind the hall.

Tara: What about the food stalls?

Imran: Stall owners have agreed to keep separate bins for food scraps and other waste. We will put clear signs above the bins.

Tara: Will all this be expensive?

Imran: We must pay a deposit for the cups, but we expect to get it back after returning them. Reducing waste is worth the effort.

1. What will replace plastic cups, and why? (2)
2. Where can visitors return used cups? (1)
3. Who washes the cups and where? (2)
4. What will stall owners do with waste? (2)
5. Why does Imran expect to recover the deposit? (2)
6. Find a word meaning "used again." (1)

Answers: 1. Washable, reusable steel cups will replace disposable plastic cups. 2. At two return desks. 3. A local group will wash them in clean water behind the hall. 4. They will use separate bins for food scraps and other waste. 5. The committee expects the deposit back when it returns the cups. 6. reused.

Passage D: Sport and study

Coach: Why did you miss practice yesterday, Maya?

Maya: I had a science test this morning and needed extra revision. I should have informed you earlier.

Coach: Thank you for saying so. How can you manage both next week?

Maya: I can revise for an hour before dinner and attend practice on Tuesday and Thursday.

Coach: The match is on Saturday. Can you come for a short session on Friday too?

Maya: Yes, if it ends by five. My bus leaves at five fifteen.

Coach: Agreed. We will practise passing, not play a full match. Remember to rest on Friday night.

Maya: I will. I want to play well without neglecting my studies.

1. Why did Maya miss practice, and what does she admit she should have done? (2)
2. On which two days can she attend regular practice? (2)
3. Why must Friday's session end by five? (1)
4. What will the team practise on Friday instead of playing a full match? (1)
5. How does Maya plan to balance sport and study? Give three details. (3)
6. Find a word meaning "not giving enough attention to." (1)

Answers: 1. She revised for a science test and admits she should have informed the coach earlier. 2. Tuesday and Thursday. 3. Her bus leaves at five fifteen. 4. Passing. 5. She will revise before dinner, attend two regular practices and join a short Friday session; she also intends to rest. 6. neglecting.

Part III · Grammar practice

Question tags and common errors

For a positive statement use a negative tag and vice versa; *rarely, seldom, few, no* usually make the clause negative. Match the auxiliary and subject, including *aren't I?*, *shall we?* after *let's*, and *will you?* for requests.

A. Add tags (try all eight).

1. The bus has left, _____?
2. She doesn't play tennis, _____?
3. Let's start now, _____?
4. I am early, _____?
5. Nobody called us, _____?
6. He seldom misses class, _____?
7. Please close the door, _____?
8. Everyone enjoyed the play, _____?

Answers: 1. hasn't it? 2. does she? 3. shall we? 4. aren't I? 5. did they? 6. does he? 7. will you? 8. didn't they? (*Everyone* takes singular verb in the statement but commonly *they* in the tag.)

B. Correct and rewrite each sentence (try all eight).

1. One of my friend lives in Jorhat.
2. She prefers tea than coffee.
3. He is an university student.
4. The teacher, along with her pupils, are ready.
5. I have lived here since three years.
6. Neither of the answers are correct.
7. This is a useful informations.
8. He is senior than me.

Answers: 1. One of my friends lives in Jorhat. 2. She prefers tea to coffee. 3. He is a university student. 4. The teacher, along with her pupils, is ready. 5. I have lived here for three years. 6. Neither of the answers is correct. 7. This is useful information. 8. He is senior to me.

Final check: follow the actual half-yearly paper's instructions for choices and marks.

Voice: active and passive

Active: the subject does the action: “The teacher praised Rina.” **Passive:** the object receives it: “Rina was praised by the teacher.” Keep the tense and meaning the same. Use a suitable form of *be* + the past participle (V3). Add “by” only when the doer matters. A sentence without an object usually cannot be changed into a normal passive sentence.

Quick forms: writes → is written; wrote → was written; is writing → is being written; has written → has been written; will write → will be written; can write → can be written.

Try these. Change the voice:

1. Rina writes a letter.
2. The boys cleaned the room.
3. The chef is cooking dinner.
4. They have repaired the road.
5. The teacher will check the copies.
6. Someone stole my bag.

Answers

1. A letter is written by Rina.
2. The room was cleaned by the boys.
3. Dinner is being cooked by the chef.
4. The road has been repaired.
5. The copies will be checked by the teacher.

6. My bag was stolen.

Tense: choose the correct verb

Present simple: habits and facts (“She goes to school every day”). **Present continuous:** happening now (“She is studying now”). **Present perfect:** completed action with a link to now (“She has finished her work”). **Past simple:** finished past time (“She finished it yesterday”). **Past continuous:** action in progress in the past (“She was reading when I called”). **Past perfect:** earlier of two past actions (“She had left before I arrived”). **Future simple:** “She will return tomorrow.” Time words help, but check the whole sentence.

Try these. Use the correct form of the verb:

1. She ____ (go) to school every day.
2. Listen! The birds ____ (sing).
3. We ____ (visit) our aunt yesterday.
4. He ____ (finish) the work already.
5. When I reached the station, the train ____ (leave).
6. They ____ (play) football when it began to rain.
7. I ____ (call) you tomorrow.
8. She ____ (live) here since 2020.

Answers

1. goes
2. are singing
3. visited
4. has finished
5. had left
6. were playing
7. will call
8. has lived

Scope: these are original practice exercises for the topics in your supplied half-yearly syllabus, not questions predicted from the paper.

Part IV · Optional essay practice

Essay writing is **not listed** in the supplied 2026 half-yearly syllabus. These ten model essays are extra practice only, not predicted topics. A simple structure is: title, short introduction, two or three distinct points with examples, then a conclusion. Follow the actual question paper if an essay is asked.

1. Women Empowerment

Women empowerment means giving women the freedom and opportunity to shape their own lives. It begins at home, where a daughter deserves the same encouragement to learn and dream as a son.

Education opens doors, but opportunity must follow it. A young woman should be able to choose a profession, earn fairly and make decisions about her future. Safe public spaces, respectful workplaces and access to healthcare are equally important. Families can help by sharing household work instead of treating it as a woman's duty alone.

Empowerment is not a contest between women and men. When a woman can use her abilities, her family and community benefit too. A teacher guides children, an entrepreneur creates jobs, and a leader can speak for those whose voices are seldom heard.

Laws matter, but attitudes matter just as much. We should challenge unfair jokes, listen to girls and support their ambitions. A society grows stronger when everyone has room to grow.

2. Global Warming and the Future of Mankind

Global warming is the gradual rise in Earth's temperature. Human activities, especially burning coal, oil and gas, add heat-trapping gases to the atmosphere. The result is not only hotter days; changing weather can affect farms, homes and health.

In Assam, a flood can interrupt classes and damage a family's livelihood. Elsewhere, drought may leave farmers without enough water. Wildlife also suffers when forests and habitats change. Poor families often have the fewest resources to recover from such losses.

There is no single magic solution. Governments must support cleaner energy, protect forests and prepare communities for extreme weather. We can save electricity, avoid waste and choose public transport when practical. Planting trees helps, but protecting mature trees matters as well.

The future of mankind depends on choices made today. We do not need to live without comfort; we need to use resources wisely. If people work together, a safer and fairer future is still possible.

3. Youth Empowerment

Young people are often called the future of a country, but they are also part of its present. Youth empowerment means giving them knowledge, skills and a genuine chance to take part in decisions.

Education should teach more than answers for an examination. Students need to ask questions, work with others and learn practical skills. A village youth group, for example, can organise a reading corner or help keep a riverbank clean. Such work builds confidence and a sense of responsibility.

Adults have a role too. They should listen without dismissing every new idea, provide safe spaces for discussion and guide young people through mistakes. Access to training and fair employment matters more than empty praise. Young women and men must receive equal opportunities.

Young people also need to use freedom responsibly. They should check information before sharing it and respect different opinions. With support and self-discipline, their energy can become useful action that improves both their lives and their communities.

4. India's North-East as a Tourism Destination

India's North-East invites visitors with its rivers, hills, forests and living traditions. In Assam, the Brahmaputra shapes daily life, while tea gardens and local markets offer different ways to understand the region. A journey here can be more than a collection of photographs.

Travellers can learn from local food, crafts, music and festivals. They can stay in small homestays and speak with hosts about their surroundings. Such visits can support guides, drivers, artisans and family businesses. Yet tourism also brings pressure: litter, crowded roads and damage to fragile places.

Good tourism should therefore respect people and nature. Visitors can follow local rules, avoid plastic waste and pay fairly for services. Communities should have a voice in how tourism develops, rather than losing control of their homes to outsiders.

The North-East is not a single culture or a single landscape. Its beauty lies in its variety. A thoughtful visitor returns with memories and leaves the place worthy of another visit.

5. Knowledge Is Power

Knowledge helps us understand the world and make better choices. It is more than remembering facts for an examination. When we ask questions, read carefully and learn from experience, we become less likely to believe every rumour we hear.

A farmer uses knowledge to care for crops, while a nurse uses it to help a patient. Students can use it to recognise their strengths and plan a useful path. Even simple knowledge, such as how to keep drinking water clean, can protect a family. The internet makes information easy to find, but it also makes false claims easy to spread. That is why we must check a source before sharing it.

Knowledge is most valuable when it is used with kindness. A person who knows a great deal but refuses to listen to others may still make poor decisions. We should learn throughout life and share what we learn. In this way, knowledge gives us the power to help ourselves and our communities.

6. Sports as a Career in India

Sport can be more than a hobby. A skilled player may become an athlete, coach, referee or trainer. There are also jobs in sports medicine, event management and journalism. Yet talent alone does not build a career. Regular practice, good guidance and patience are necessary.

Many young people begin by playing at school. They need safe grounds, proper equipment and chances to compete. Families and teachers can encourage them without forcing them to leave their studies. Education remains useful because sporting careers can change through injury or age. Financial support is also important for talented students who cannot afford travel or training.

A sporting career should not be measured only by fame. A good local coach can change many lives by helping children grow stronger and more confident. India can support young athletes by improving facilities and making opportunities fair. If students work steadily and have honest support, sport can become a meaningful profession.

7. The Importance of Ecological Conservation

Ecological conservation means protecting the living world and using natural resources with care. Forests, rivers, soil and wildlife are connected. When one part is damaged, people and other living things can suffer too.

A river may provide drinking water, fish and work for nearby families. If it fills with waste, those benefits begin to disappear. Forests give shelter to animals and help protect the land. Cutting them without thought can make the environment weaker. Conservation is not only about distant animals; it also matters to farmers, students and future generations.

Governments must enforce sensible rules, but ordinary people have a part to play. We can reduce waste, save water, keep public places clean and support efforts to protect local habitats. Planting trees is helpful when they are cared for, but existing forests need protection as well.

Development and conservation need not be enemies. We can build a better life while respecting the natural systems that make life possible.

8. The Value of Education

Education gives us the tools to read, think and express ourselves. It can help us find work, but its value is wider than a salary. A good education teaches us to examine an idea, listen to someone else and solve a problem without giving up.

A classroom can bring students from different backgrounds together. They learn subjects, but they also learn to cooperate and disagree respectfully. Teachers play an important role when they welcome questions instead of asking students to memorise every answer. Families can help by encouraging curiosity and making time for study.

Education should be available to everyone. A child may struggle because of distance, money or duties at home, not because of a lack of ability. Libraries, scholarships and patient teaching can help remove such barriers.

Examinations matter, but they are only one part of learning. An educated person should be willing to keep learning and use knowledge responsibly. That makes education valuable to both the individual and society.

9. Social Media: Benefits and Risks

Social media helps people stay in touch, learn new skills and share their work. A student can watch a lesson, a small business can reach customers, and relatives living far apart can speak easily. These are real benefits when the platforms are used with care.

The same speed can also cause harm. A false story may travel before anyone checks it. Hours spent scrolling can take time away from sleep, study and face-to-face conversation. Public comments can hurt a person, and private details may reach people we never meant to share them with.

We need not reject social media completely. We can check the source of a claim, ask permission before posting someone else's photo and set aside time to be offline. If an online argument becomes cruel, leaving it can be wiser than winning it.

Technology works best when we control how we use it. Social media should help us connect and learn, not decide how we feel about ourselves.

10. My Dream Holiday Destination

My dream holiday destination is a quiet village in the hills of North-East India. I would like to wake up to cool air, walk along a small path and hear stories from the people who live there. I would rather understand one place slowly than hurry through many places for photographs.

I would visit local markets, taste unfamiliar food and learn about the crafts made in the village. A guide could explain the plants and birds along a walking trail. In the evening, I would sit with a notebook and write about the day. A holiday like this would give me a break from traffic, screens and a crowded timetable.

Being a guest brings responsibilities. I would follow local rules, pay fairly for services and carry my waste back with me. I would also ask before photographing people. The best journey is not simply one that gives us memories. It should leave the place and its community treated with respect.

Sources and scope

- Primary: *Harmony: An Anthology of Prose & Poetry*, the student's downloaded Harmony-XII-Fullbook.pdf. The Strange Meeting text, summary and textbook questions appear on PDF pp. 86–90. The six assigned selections and comprehension guidance are based on this textbook.
- The 2026 half-yearly topic list came directly from the student. Exercises and answers are revision practice, not an official answer key. Follow the actual question paper for marks and choices.